

Idealism and nature



German Romantic artists such as Caspar David Friedrich explored the relationship between man and nature.

The period of German idealism coincided with the growth of the Romantic movement in the arts. With its emphasis on emotion and fascination with nature, Romanticism developed as a reaction to scientific rationalization and industrialization, but was also influenced by Rousseau's view of a state of nature and Spinoza's pantheism (see [Jean-Jacques Rousseau](#) and [Spinoza: God and nature](#)).

Among the circle of German Romantic artists, writers and intellectuals was Friedrich Schelling, whose philosophy of nature chimed with their ideals. Schelling reacted against Fichte's ideas, arguing that a knowing subject cannot exist without an object, and vice versa. Reality is not a creation of the 'I' – there is no difference between subjective experience and objective external reality. So life is not separate from matter, and nature is a living thing, a continually developing process characterized by its creativity. For Schelling, human creativity represents the highpoint of nature's development towards self-awareness.